



Know The Real Petition

A Valid Petition

- ▶ Almost always supported by an established organisation such as the Worldwide Fund for Nature or Greenpeace
- ▶ These do not carry a must-forward clause. The receiver is free to forward it if he so wishes
- ▶ These are usually based on an issue you have heard of or read before

Spam

- ▶ Supported by organisations that you've never heard of before; chances are no one has. Example: Mothers Against Drunken Driving
- ▶ Always has a must-forward clause
- ▶ The issues being dealt with are not concrete. Mostly talk of direct help. For example, "Forward this mail to XXX people, and for every forward, Microsoft (or some other major company) will contribute \$1 to the cause."

Cyber-activism transcends geographical limitations and ensures the issue is kept alive 24/7.

To illustrate this point, an online petition to push for a permanent seat for India in the United Nations Security Council (UNSC), put up on www.sulekha.com, a networking hub for Indians from around the world, garnered more than 55,000 signatures from across 120 countries. What's more interesting is that many of these signatories were willing to take time out and volunteer for the cause.

Many hardline activists, though, are not sold to the idea of the strategic effect of an online petition. What is increasingly being realised, though, is that the Internet could not only play a significant role in tackling these pressing problems, but also has the potential of letting the oppressed speak out and be heard.

Petitions, Causes, Blogs

The Internet helps activists save costs in collecting and distributing information, finding like-minded people to support a cause and training them, and raising funds for the purpose. People in remote areas can participate just as effectively in e-mail discussions, like those in larger cities. Increasingly, as the medium itself becomes cheaper to access and more multimedia-like in nature, it opens up to a larger segments of society. Those affected might finally have a way to tell the world of their plight, without needing intermediaries.

Activism on the Net can be broadly classified into two categories. One involves signing a pre-drafted petition, many of which are put up on sites such as www.petitiononline.com, www.petitionspot.com, www.ipetitions.com, and www.thepetitionsite.com.

These sites have petitions indexed by topic and area. Registering a petition is really simple; however, www.petitiononline.com, for example, does not have a moderator to sift through the non-serious petitions. This results in a large number of inane petitions like "Get my girlfriend back!" by Douglas Cornell of 'Doug loves Shannon Inc.'.

In the other type, one uses a blog or Web site dedicated to a single cause. Examples are www.cleanwateraction.org, www.greenpeace.org,

College students form the majority of cyber-activists today

Shailendra Yashwant,
Campaign Director,
Greenpeace India

www.makingindiagreen.org and www.oneworld.net, which have people registered with them as cyber-activists.

A different kind of example is networking sites such as www.actionnetwork.org, which functions as a gateway to as many as 170 leading environment, health and population advocacy organisations. These cyber-activists are kept updated about various protests and activities through a regular newsletter. Activists can also download action kits, send Flash-animated post-cards to friends, and play informative games.

The Scene In India

Cyber-activism has been around in India ever since the Education and Research Network—the ERNET—set up by the Government of India and the United Nations Development Program (UNDP), gained some popularity.

The first known case of a movement on the Net was back in 1995, at a time when BBSes (Bulletin Board Services) comprised much of ERNET. Enthusiasts ran the BBSes in their spare time, using their own funds. The government suddenly deemed these as profit-making corporations fit for taxation. And the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) decided that Rs 15 lakh annually from each BBS operator as a 'license fee' was appropriate.

Obviously, no operator could afford this. There was an uproar, and a group called FREE was formed. They fought the case and by active lobbying, won. The license fee was withdrawn. This was India's first brush with online activism.

The scenario today is very different, with an unregulated Internet, and a large connected population aware of the issues plaguing it. The popularity of the Internet as a medium for communication has altered the demographic break up of today's cyber-activists. "College students form the majority of cyber-activists today, but there are also housewives and teachers with access to computers at home who participate in our cyber-actions," says Shailendra Yashwant, campaign director, Greenpeace India.

India has the largest number—and the widest range—of NGOs and it is therefore natural for cyber-activism to be active here.

One of the longest sustained campaigns has been the one against genetically modified (or GM) foodgrains and crops. Many environmental groups including Greenpeace claim India is being converted into a dumping ground or testing area by major multinationals.

More Than The Birds And The Bees

Environmentalists have been at the forefront of using the Internet as a formidable tool of protest. Almost all major groups working towards the protection of the environment have a strong presence in cyberspace.

The Worldwide Fund for Nature (www.panda.org), too, has a cyber-activism cell, akin to the one run by Greenpeace. However, its activities are not as aggressive. Other organisations such as PETA (People for Ethical Treatment of Animals) India do not have a specific online activism cell,

